

# **The Idolisation of Populist Leaders: Analysing Donald Trump, Elon Musk and “Politics as Fandom” in the Hybrid Media System**

## **1. Introduction:**

In the contemporary digital landscape, the boundaries separating serious political discourse, media representation and the entertainment industries have become increasingly fluid. Historically, political communication operated through heavily mediated, one-way channels controlled by mainstream media (MSM) institutions. However, the rise of web-native, interactive platforms has decentralised this landscape, giving birth to a hybrid media-system where digital pop culture, algorithmic communication, and identity politics converge. This essay investigates the contemporary phenomenon of political figures being treated not merely as policy-makers, but as cultural icons, idols, and centers of digital fandoms. ▀

Using the case study of Donald Trump’s digital political ecosystem, specifically focusing on his strategic utilisation of short-form video memes, algorithmic echo chambers and his high-profile digital alliance with tech billionaire Elon Musk this paper deconstructs how modern populist figures cultivate intensely loyal fan bases. ▀ It argues that digital communication technologies have fundamentally altered democratic engagement; rather than participating in civic discourse through rational policy evaluation, the contemporary public increasingly interacts with

politics through emotional investments, social identities, and tribal dynamics characteristic of popular media fandom.

## **2. Background Information:**

The selected case study centers on the transformation of mainstream American and global politics into a high-stakes form of digital entertainment a phenomenon epitomised by Donald Trump's media strategies. Over the past decade, Trump has actively shifted political communication away from traditional institutional norms toward the production of hyper-relatable, highly meme-able, and adversarial content. In this digital campaign ecosystem, complex socioeconomic agendas are routinely condensed into fifteen-second video formats, curated Tiktok soundtracks, and strategic internet micro-celebrity aesthetic.

This environment was profoundly accelerated by Elon Musk's acquisition of X (formerly Twitter) and his subsequent active endorsement of Trump, Musk, operating as a mega-influencer with hundreds of millions of followers, effectively turned his platform into a structural megaphone for Trump-centric populist drama, frequently interacting with MAGA internet subcultures and amplifying viral meme formats.

This trend is not an isolated marketing anomaly but a systemic cultural shift reflecting a profound crisis of authority engulfing mainstream establishment media. As public trust in traditional journalism continues to erode globally, decentralised social media platforms and elite tech

influencers fill the vacuum, effectively mutating serious ideological battles into hypervisible, fast-paced popular culture narratives.

### **3. Theoretical Framework:**

To rigorously unpack the sociopolitical dimensions of this phenomenon, this paper utilises the academic concept of Politics as an object of fandom: advanced by political communication, Allen and Moon (2023) argue that a significant portion of the public who heavily follow political developments do so from the perspective of an invested fan. They observe that this closely mirrors how audiences interact with traditional forms of entertainment, such as sports leagues or reality television programming. This theoretical lens shifts the analytical focus away from traditional political science metrics toward the affective and cultural dimensions of audience reception.♥

Fandom, in this context, is defined as a structured space of intense emotional investment, communal belonging, and identity performance. By applying this framework, the essay moves past simplistic media effect theories to evaluate how digital media infrastructures provide the specific tools or affordances that encourage ordinary citizens to adopt the behavior, language, and defensive psychology of media fans when participating in modern political spheres.

### **4. Critical Analysis & Significance:**

#### **Algorithmic Affordances and the Architecture of Online Tribalism:**

The mutation of political engagement into fandom cannot be understood without critically analysing the technological architecture of social media

platforms. Contemporary digital ecosystems possess specific affordances—structural properties designed to encourage and enable distinct modes of user interaction. Platforms are fundamentally governed by algorithmic systems engineered to maximise user engagement, retention and screen time. Because nuanced, objective policy analysis rarely generates high interaction metrics, algorithms prioritise hyper-emotional, sensational and polarising content.

This technical dynamic fosters a profound compatibility between the structural mechanics of social media and populist political movements, where digital environments amplify direct, unmediated emotional connections between a leader and the populace while bypassing institutional journalistic filters (Gerbaudo 2014). The algorithm naturally segments audiences into highly insular networks, colloquially known as echo chambers. Within Donald Trump's digital echo chambers, which are structurally validated and protected by platform owners like Elon Musk, the political leader is systematically deified, while dissenting opinions are filtered out.

Consequently, the public is encouraged to perform rigid in-group and out-group dynamics. The mechanical architecture of these isolated online feeds directly drives cognitive polarisation (Jiang Ren and Ferrara 2021). The internal group comprises the loyal MAGA fan community, who views Trump as an authentic protector of their values, whereas the external group is cast as a corrupt establishment, an elite enemy, or a hostile anti-fan collective. When an individual interacts with a Trump-Musk meme online, they are not merely disseminating data; they are actively performing their alignment with a specific digital tribe, a practice identical to sports fandom or pop-music stan culture.

However, to maintain a necessary critical distance from the scholarship, it is important to address a prominent gap in Allen and Moon's (2023) theoretical model. While their framework is highly effective at diagnosing the emotional symptoms of political devotion, it treats fandom as a largely spontaneous, consumer-driven choice. In doing so, it downplays how underlying platform mechanics structurally force these behaviors. As argued by Wells et al. (2016), Donald Trump's political ascendancy was not merely an organic fluke of personal charisma but a calculated exploitation of systematic media affordances that hybrid platforms inherently prioritise. Thus, political fandom is not just a subcultural preference; it is actively manufactured and reinforced by the tech-capital infrastructure itself.

### **The Aesthetics of Drama over Materiality**

Furthermore, viewing politics through the prism of fandom significantly reshapes how society values political outcomes. When political figures are treated as cultural idols, public focus shifts drastically from the objective substance of a policy to the stylistic performance and drama of the narrative. The traditional democratic ideal assumes a citizenry that judges a leader based on legislation, economic indicators, and ethical governance. In stark contrast, digital political fandom prioritises narrative drama, rhetorical wit, and stylistic dominance. Modern political consumers engage with the state apparatus as a long-running, episodic television series filled with protagonists, villains, and shocking plot twists.

This aestheticisation means that Donald Trump's viral, sarcastic retorts or Elon Musk's witty, anti-establishment posts can completely

overshadow catastrophic policy failures or ethical breaches. The figure's performance of authenticity often manufactured through calculated PR strategies is accepted by fans as genuine truth. Data from global industry indexes indicate that institutional leaders are experiencing a severe crisis of credibility, with a majority of the public believing that both politicians and journalists deliberately attempt to manipulate public narratives (Edelman 2024).<sup>1</sup> In this climate of pervasive skepticism, the traditional, rational public sphere fractures. It is replaced by highly emotional, counter-public fan spaces where the validation of one's pre-existing identity and collective belonging within the fandom takes precedence over objective socio-political reality.

### **Cultural Backlash, Populism, and Parallels to the Australian Context**

The wider sociocultural significance of this phenomenon is clearly observable within specific national contexts. The intersection of digital populism, fandom, and identity often manifests as a form of right-wing cultural backlash against rapid progressive societal changes. Online right-wing populist networks routinely leverage digital media platforms to reconstruct distinct notions of citizenship and traditional masculinity (Nilan et al 2025). In Australia, digital political groups frequently construct a romanticised, populist imagery of the ordinary, authentic citizen historically rooted in local populist archetypes like the "Aussie Battler" and position their preferred political idols as the sole defenders of this identity against globalist or progressive elites (Nilan et al. 2025).

While Trump and Musk operate on a global scale, the structural mechanics remain identical to the local Australian context. Digital

communication channels enable these counter-publics to organise highly coordinated online campaigns, weaponising humor, memes, and Internet slang to attack political opponents. This demonstrates that political fandom is rarely just about passive admiration; it is an active, identity-driven cultural struggle where digital spaces are utilised to claim social dominance and reshape the national cultural fabric.

## **5. Professional Application to Digital Communication and Public Relations**

For aspiring professionals entering the fields of Digital Communication and Public Relations (PR), the structural transition toward political fandom offers critical strategic insights and profound ethical warnings. First, this phenomenon completely redefines the parameters of modern Reputation Management. In an era dominated by decentralised, hybrid media systems, PR practitioners can no longer rely entirely on top-down, traditional media strategies. To effectively capture public attention, brands, corporations, and organizations must adopt communication tactics originally honed by cultural celebrities and digital political campaigns. This involves optimising content for platform-specific algorithmic affordances, shifting toward highly visual, authentic, and relational micro-content (such as short-form videos and interactive memes), and actively nurturing community-driven spaces to foster organic consumer loyalty.

Second, the intense tribalism of online fandom underscores the urgent need for advanced Crisis Communication capabilities. Because modern digital audiences are heavily compartmentalised into insular echo chambers, corporate or organisational crisis can instantly become polarised “dramas” weaponised by opposing online factions.

Understanding the architectural layout and polarising tendencies of these closed spaces is highly essential to counteract the systemic alignment generated by algorithmic setups (Jiang, Ren, and Ferrara 2021). PR professionals must possess the analytical data literacy to track real-time sentiment shifts across internet subcultures, identifying potential in-group versus out-group flashpoints before they escalate into uncontrollable public boycotts.

Most importantly, this cultural shift demands a renewed commitment to Communication Ethics. The strategies analysed in this essay show that invoking populist demagoguery and exploiting emotional algorithmic biases can yield massive short-term engagement metrics. However, deliberately fabricating outrage, relying on sensationalist misinformation, or pitting social groups against one another severely degrades public trust and destroys long-term social equity. ♥PR and digital media professionals have a socio-ethical responsibility to employ the mechanisms of digital community building responsibly. They must strive to construct highly engaged online spaces centered around transparent narrative values, ethical corporate citizenship, and constructive public dialogue, rather than capitalising on hyper-polarisation and societal fragmentation.

## **6. Conclusion:**

In conclusion, the contemporary intersection of popular culture and media communication has profoundly destabilised traditional democratic frameworks. As deconstructed through the lens of Allen and Moon's (2023) theoretical model, the rise of politics as an object of fandom

represents a systemic mutation in how the public perceives, internalises and participates in civic life. Driven by the engagement-maximizing affordances of social media platforms, contemporary citizens are systematically conditioned to abandon rational, policy-driven deliberation in favor of affective tribalism and narrative entertainment.

The digital alliances between figures like Donald Trump and Elon Musk present a stark cultural observation: political actors are no longer evaluated merely on their legislative or material performance but on their stylistic efficacy as digital pop icons. For future digital communication and PR practitioners, navigating this complex terrain does not require inventing a utopian solution to societal polarisation. Rather, it demands developing a highly sophisticated literacy of these hybrid media spaces-learning to utilise the unparalleled community-building power of digital networks while resolutely upholding the strict ethical standards necessary to preserve authentic public communication and restore civic trust.

## Reference List:

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